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The Nuba

Author(S): Nadel, S. F. (Siegfried Frederick)

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Offences against prohibited degrees, committed through marriage or, above all, illicit sexual relations, entail neither supernatural nor secular sanctions—save the ‘anger’ of the families. Indeed, the Mesakin mention the lapsing of certain marriage prohibitions as though it represented an intelligible and on the whole harmless change. Incest in the narrow sense, between biological relations, is an exception: for this, much graver, offence is said to be punished, by the act of God, with leprosy. The interpretation of what is or is not incest is somewhat fluid. The reaction to incest dreams is one of horror and revulsion only if the dream is about a (real) brother or sister (both tribes deny the occurrence of incest dreams about mothers or fathers). If a man dreamed in this way about his classificatory sister, his cousin, or possibly his brother's wife, he would think nothing of it and might even joke about it with the heroine of his dream. Yet of the two cases of incest (both unquestionably that, as both were said to have been followed by leprosy) which I recorded in Mesakin, one was with a biological sister, the other with a *narane* (cross-cousin). I must add that the informants first denied that incest ever happened in the tribe; later they recollected these two cases, which occurred during the last ten or fifteen years, still insisting that crimes of this kind had been unheard of in their fathers' time.

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The large majority of Korongo and Mesakin men seem to have one wife only. Marriage is universal—or very nearly so. The only exceptions are the sexual pervers among the men, homosexuals who wear women's clothing, do women's work, and adopt women's ways. This form of homosexuality coupled with transvesticism is more widespread in these two tribes than in all other Nuba groups which I have studied. It also goes further in its social consequences. It involves a nominal marriage between the transvestite

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(called *londo* in Korongo and *tubele* in Mesakin) and another man, for a bride-price of one goat. 'Wife' and husband live together and keep a common household. The 'marriage' rarely lasts long: the 'husband' is as a rule a young man who will outgrow his homosexual leanings, or who had been induced to play this part by the promise of an easy life. He would soon tire of the unnatural life and abandon it for real marriage, not without having to face first the angry pleadings of his male 'wife'. The fact that he had lived in this homosexual union does not disqualify him for marriage in the eyes of the women. In fact, I heard of two Mesakin men who had each for a time lived with two 'wives', one male and one female. The jealousy and constant bickerings between the two 'co-wives' soon broke up the unequal union.

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Lack of virility in the wider sense of the word constitutes a serious disqualification for marriage. A weakling, an effeminate man, who could never prove his worth in the exigent tribal sports, would find a wife only with difficulty. Though he would not actually be forced to remain single, no self-respecting girl would marry him, and he would have to be content with a widow or a girl whom no one else would have. 'How can I marry a man', the women would argue, 'who is afraid of a spear?' ■ 286 One day an enemy might try to kidnap my child or steal a goat, and my husband would be unable to stop him,' Both Korongo and Mesakin make much of love as the only basis for marriage: love, with them, goes with manly valour.

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

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